Branching Out

As the company launched regular operations it required more office space. In April 1907, the company's registered office appears to have shifted to Pereira's buildings at No. 4 Beach Road, near the post office in Tuticorin,[20] even though it continued to hold on to its original office on 85, Great Cotton Road.[21]

Parallel to the process of registration of the company, or shortly afterwards, SSNCo began establishing branches. In the initial stages at least, the primary function of the branches other than the one at Colombo would have been to raise capital by selling shares.

Given that Colombo was pivotal to the business of SSNCo it is likely that the company's first branch office was opened there, though we do not know the exact dates. The Colombo branch was located—possibly right from the early days—at 10, Consister Buildings, Fort before it moved to 4, Queen's Street, Fort in November 1907.[22] The office continued to function there at least until November 1908 when its Agent contemplated a shift 'to a more suitable place' on Baillie Street also in the Fort.[23] The Colombo Agent was C. Thumbayya (C. Thumbayya Mudaliar). The Tuticorin merchant Bravi Roche Victoria's[24] father, Gerald Christian Roche Victoria, a sub-contractor in Colombo, appears to have acted as manager of SSNCo at Colombo when the company started operations with chartered ships.[25] A letter from Thumbayya, dating to September 1908, gives further names: 'Mr Sivakolundan is still my Sub-Agent, and Messrs Narayanaswamy Pillai and Caderamen are still in my service … Vadivaloo has joined the Boat Coy.'[26] From this we can gather that the Colombo branch employed many hands and that most of the above-mentioned were on its payroll from its inception.

If Colombo was vital to SSNCo's operations, the importance of Bombay lay in another direction. With the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869, the hub of Indian maritime activity had shifted from Calcutta to Bombay. The city teemed with shippers, brokers, agents, stevedores and a range of other maritime professionals. The Bombay dockyards also offered the best